YOUR PARENTING PROFILE



The Pretzel

P G D E

Rules that twist into games.

Your four letters

Your code is built from four research-backed parenting dimensions. Neither pole of any dimension is the better one.



P
HOW YOU ORGANIZE THE DAY
Planner

G
WHO SETS THE DIRECTION
Gardener

D
WHEN THE FEELINGS GET BIG
Doer

E
COMFORT ZONE OR STRETCH ZONE
Explorer

For fun & reflection — not a clinical assessment or diagnostic tool.

AN EVERYDAY STORY

The Saturday Without a Mission

On Saturday morning, the living room is covered in toys. Usually you can turn cleanup into a treasure hunt, a timer challenge, or a dramatic rescue mission. Today your body feels heavy. Your child waits for the game to begin, and guilt taps your shoulder: If I were more present, I could make this fun.

As a Pretzel parent, you bend ordinary rules into play. Movement is how you connect and how you keep a hard day from feeling stuck. But being the engine of fun all the time leaves no place for your own tiredness.



So today you let cleanup be boring. You put on one song for yourself, move slowly, and ask everyone to return five things. No storyline. No lesson. No camera.

Later, you sit on the floor together and ask, “What was annoying today?” Your child says, “Cleaning.” You both laugh. The day did not need an adventure to count. The quiet check-in gives the ordinary moment an emotional ending, while your body learns that connection can stay even when you stop performing it.



WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS

You keep life moving: chores become games, learning happens by doing, and problems turn into missions. When a day stays ordinary, you can feel less present or less creative.

RELEASE THE GUILT

Your child does not need every task to become an adventure. Flat, ordinary days are part of a safe childhood too, you do not have to be an endless fun machine.



YOUR SUPERPOWERS

1. Chores become missions in your house
2. Learning happens hands-on, knee-deep, mid-puddle
3. Mess doesn't scare you one bit

WATCH-OUT, WITH LOVE

Action-first can skip the debrief. Name the feeling after the fun, it seals the lesson. 🥨

YOUR POP-CULTURE COUSIN

Free-range with a curriculum



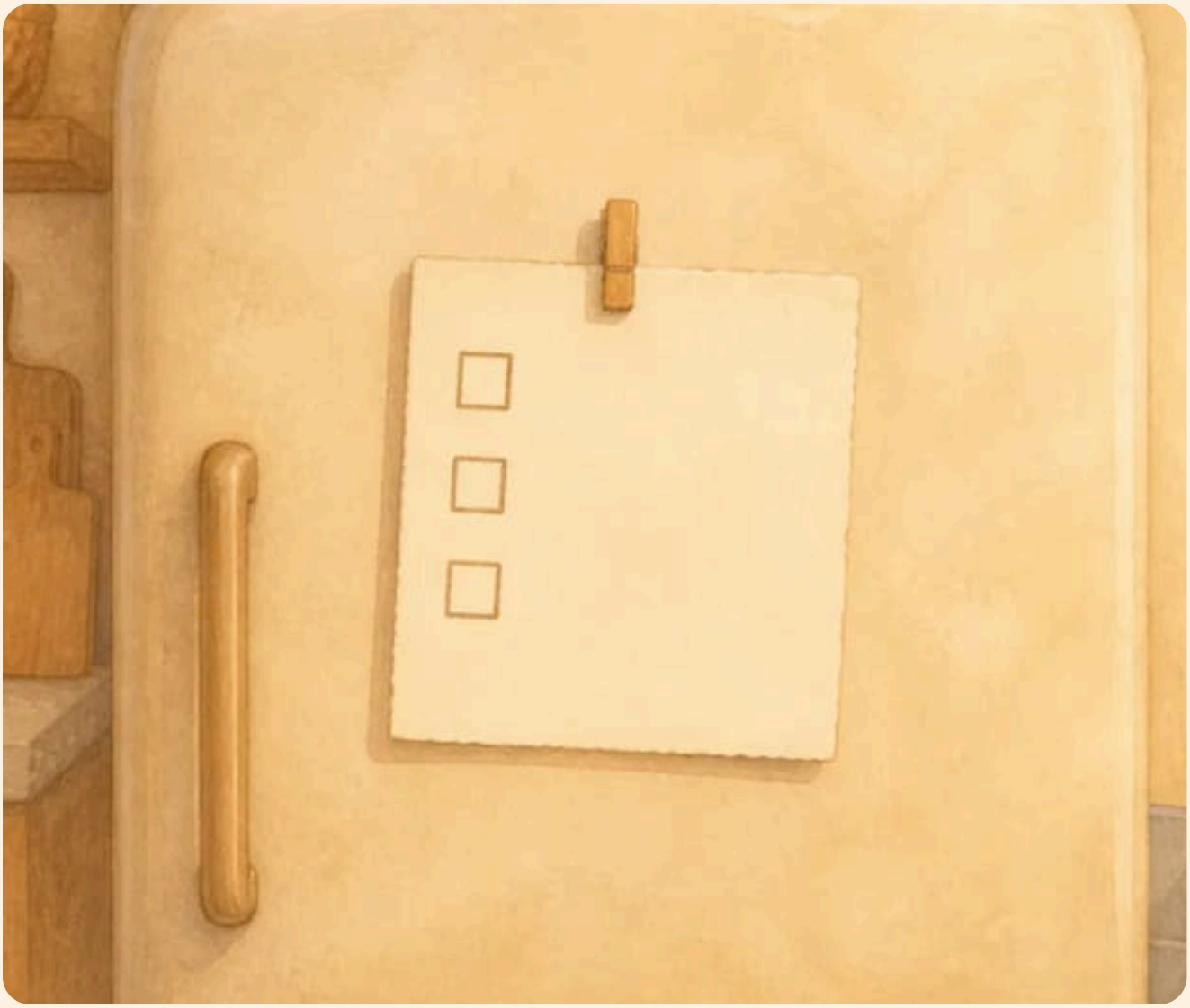
WHAT TO REMEMBER

Try this week

- [ ] Let one chore stay ordinary
- [ ] Move your body for 10 minutes just for you
- [ ] After play, ask: “Which part was fun or frustrating?”

EXTRAS FOR YOUR STYLE

- [ ] Let one plan change without correcting it.
- [ ] Set one limit and hold it to the end.
- [ ] Before you fix it, say one feeling word first.
- [ ] Stop at the first try if they say that's enough.



FOR YOU FIRST

5 ways to come back to yourself

Chosen from your style: what you spend yourself on is what needs releasing. Not one of these is for your child.

There's an order most of us have backwards: everyone else gets looked after first, and you get whatever is left. But what's left at nine at night isn't you — it's the part of you that never got to rest.

The next five pages don't ask you to be a better parent. Nothing here is counted, nothing is reported, and not one of them is for your child. They're all for you, and they aren't a reward you have to earn first.

What's on them isn't random either. Every parenting style spends itself differently: some parents run out from anticipating, some from deciding, some from holding everybody's feelings. So whatever drains you most is also what most needs releasing.



WHAT DRAINS YOU MOST

P — HOW YOU ORGANIZE THE DAY

Anticipating. Your head keeps running even when your body sits down.

G — WHO SETS THE DIRECTION

Waiting and holding back. Following someone else's pace all day is work.

D — WHEN THE FEELINGS GET BIG

Doing. Loving through action means you rarely get to sit down.

E — COMFORT ZONE OR STRETCH ZONE

Being the energy. Every bit of the fun sets off from you first.

FOR YOU FIRST

Choose movement that feels good in your body without inviting, teaching, or recording anyone else.

HOW TO USE THESE

Take just one. If only one of these gets used this week, that worked. The rest stay here; they aren't going anywhere.

No time this week? You are still enough.



TIME 5 MIN

One drink while it's still hot

Almost every parent drinks their coffee cold. Not from lack of time, but because there is always one more thing that comes first.

Sit down. Finish the whole thing at its actual temperature, doing nothing else at the same time.



TIME 5 MIN

Empty your head onto paper

Your head is holding every open loop because it doesn't trust anything else to remember. Paper turns out to be enough.

Write every unfinished thing on one sheet. No order, no priorities, no tidying.



TIME 2 MIN

One decision that is only yours

You spend the day following everyone else's pace. One small uncompromised choice gives back something invisible.

Decide one thing today with nobody consulted: the song, the drink, the window open or closed.



TIME 5 MIN

Sit with no task

You love by doing — fixing, tidying, preparing. Sitting still feels wrong precisely because it's what you're short of.

Sit down with nothing in your hands. Not a phone, not folding, not planning. Five minutes of no output.



TIME 5 MIN

The boring route, on purpose

Repetition isn't a failure of imagination. It's the rest your imagination is asking for.

Take the familiar way. Order the usual. Just this once, don't look for the new thing.

5 activities with your child (0–5)

One for each age range, so you can take the one that fits your child right now. Everything is already in your house.



THEN, FOR YOUR CHILD

After the activity, a short check-in helps a physical experience become an emotional experience too.



0–12 MONTHS · 10 MIN

The texture tour

Naming what a baby is touching builds language long before they can talk.

1. Pick five safe textures: a curtain, a cool window, a wooden spoon, a leaf, a towel.
2. Let their hand land first, then name it.
3. Wait for their sound or look before moving on.

You'll need: Your own house.
Safety first: Skip anything hot, sharp, electrical, or small enough to fit through a toilet-paper tube.
Grounded in: Serve and return (Harvard)



1–2 YEARS · 10 MIN

In, out, again

Repetition isn't boredom to a toddler — it's how they confirm the world is predictable.

1. Cut one hand-sized hole in a box lid, or use a wide-mouth jar.
2. Show it once, slowly, then hand it over.
3. Let them repeat it far past the point where you're bored.

You'll need: A box or wide jar, plus large objects: jar lids, blocks, wooden rings.
Safety first: Every object larger than a toilet-paper tube, and no cut edges on the hole.
Grounded in: Montessori — order



2–3 YEARS · 10 MIN

Sort it your way

You supply the objects; they supply the rule. Their rule is the point.

1. Tip out 10–15 mixed household objects and two empty bowls.
2. Say "you can sort these however you like", then stay quiet.
3. If they sort by something you'd never have chosen, that's the successful version.

You'll need: Large buttons, bottle caps, spoons, blocks, socks.

Safety first: Every object must be too large for a toilet-paper tube and have no sharp edges. An adult stays with them.

Grounded in: Montessori — sensorial



3–4 YEARS · 15 MIN

You're the customer

For parents who show love by doing: here the doing is theirs, and you're the one being served.

1. They cook, you order and eat.
2. Accept whatever arrives, including the inedible parts of the game.
3. Slip in one feeling word somewhere: "you look proud of that one".

You'll need: Pots, spoons, cups — whatever is already in the toy box.

Safety first: Nothing from the real stove.

Grounded in: Filial therapy — special play time



4–5 YEARS · 15 MIN

The cushion course

They design it, you attempt it. Being the rule-maker is practice they rarely get.

1. They design the course and set the rules.
2. You go first, and follow their rules exactly.
3. Let them change the rules mid-course, because they will.

You'll need: Cushions, tape, chairs, a blanket.

Safety first: Use only stable, non-folding chairs. Nothing to climb higher than their own hip, with an adult staying close.

Grounded in: Montessori — freedom of movement



No play today? You are still enough.

Keep it, print it, or forget it

This booklet has no targets and counts nothing. Take the one thing that helps and leave the rest.



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